The Revolution Begins Within

A Search for Truth

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Three years ago, the life I had built stopped working. Until then, I had understood progress almost entirely through things outside myself: money, status, recognition, achievement. There was always another milestone ahead, and with it the same promise: if I could reach it, I would finally be happy.

I pushed myself hard in pursuit of that promise, treating exhaustion as discipline and achievement as proof that I was moving in the right direction. Even as my mental state began to deteriorate, I kept going. Eventually, I experienced a psychotic episode. I began hallucinating, my understanding of what was happening around me became increasingly unreliable, and I was admitted to a psychiatric ward. Afterwards, I left my job and moved back in with my parents.

The months that followed were some of the most painful of my life. I had gone from the security and comfort of a software engineering career to lying in bed thinking about everything I believed I had lost. At first, all I wanted was to get myself back on track and return to the life I had before.

But the pain forced me to confront something I had spent years ignoring: how I actually felt. Once the achievements were gone, I was left with questions I had never seriously asked myself. Why was I unhappy? What was I actually chasing? What was I afraid of? What did it mean to be okay if being okay could no longer depend on reaching some future destination?

What began as an attempt to understand my own pain gradually became something much larger. At first, I was simply trying to make sense of what had happened to me, what I felt, and how I wanted to live. Over time, I realised that I was asking something broader: what was true about myself, the people around me, and the world I was part of. Only gradually did I recognise this for what it had become—a search for truth.

But that search was never orderly. One question led into another, and what I came to understand in one part of my life often changed how I understood another. Ideas appeared before I knew where they would lead. Some fell away; others opened possibilities I had never thought to consider. At times, different parts of the journey seemed to come together with extraordinary force.

What follows is an account of that process and where it led me: through questions of self, relationship, artificial intelligence, God, money, power, and institutions. These were not separate subjects, but different parts of the same effort to understand the reality I was living within. Yet however far the questions reached, I kept returning to the same place: my own understanding.

That is where this journey began. And that is where I believe the revolution begins.

Within.

PART I

The Self

01 Learning to Understand Myself

The search began with something I had spent much of my life overlooking: my own experience. I had treated my internal world as secondary to what I achieved, how I was perceived, and whether I was moving towards the life I thought I was supposed to want. My feelings mattered mostly in relation to those goals. When they helped me move forward, I listened. When they got in the way, I treated them as obstacles.

Learning to pay attention to what I actually felt changed that. My pain did not become real only when I could explain it convincingly, and my hopes did not become meaningful only when someone else approved of them. The experience of living my life already mattered from within it. I did not need to become a future version of myself before I deserved consideration.

Taking my experience seriously did not make it easy to understand. The internal world could be chaotic: feelings overlapped, contradicted one another, carried histories I was not always aware of, and changed depending on what I feared or hoped would happen. A feeling could tell me that something mattered without telling me exactly what it meant.

Nor did experiencing something make my interpretation of it true. Feeling rejected did not tell me why someone had responded as they did. Fear did not establish that what I feared would happen, and certainty did not make my understanding correct. Shame could turn silence into judgement; anger could make another person's motives seem obvious when what I knew most directly was simply that I had been hurt.

Part of the difficulty was that I never encountered the present without a history. Earlier relationships had shaped what frightened me, what I expected from others, and what I believed I had to do to be loved. Imagined futures could exert their own pull. I could respond not only to what was happening, but to what I feared might happen or desperately wanted to make happen.

There was rarely only one thing happening within me. I could want closeness and fear the vulnerability it required. I could care about someone and still be angry with them. I could want to change while also wanting to protect something that change seemed to threaten. Understanding myself meant learning to stay with those contradictions rather than forcing them too quickly into a single explanation.

That made self-understanding less about finding a convincing story and more about noticing what any story left out. I could almost always explain my reactions in ways that made them seem reasonable. The harder task was recognising the fear beneath a demand, the shame beneath a judgement, or the attempt to regain control hidden inside something I called care. Curiosity became more useful than certainty. What was I protecting? What did I need? What had this moment touched? What was I reluctant to acknowledge?

Seeing myself more clearly did not always make what I found easier to live with. I could understand where a fear came from, recognise the behaviour it produced, and still wish that part of me were not there. Knowing what was happening within me was only the beginning. I also had to learn how to remain with what I found.

02 Being Loved Before We Know How

Part of what made that possible was a growing sense that I did not have to abandon parts of myself simply because they were painful or difficult to accept. I came to associate some of that sense with something difficult to describe. During and after my psychosis, I experienced auditory hallucinations: voices I heard as though other people were speaking when no one physically present was doing so. But there was nothing consistently gentle about them. They could be painful, confrontational, and at times brutal. I felt accused, challenged, and pushed towards things about myself I did not want to face. Whatever comfort or meaning I sometimes found in them did not come from their being warm or reassuring.

I did not always respond gently either. Sometimes I became angry and said or did things intended to hurt the voices, especially when I felt attacked or overwhelmed. Afterwards, I could recognise responses I was not proud of. Yet what I heard would often seem to return me to what had happened, why I had reacted as I did, and what I was struggling to understand. I came to experience this not simply as continued confrontation, but as something that had not given up on me.

That distinction mattered. It was not the harshness itself that I associated with love. It was the sense that responding in a way I regretted had not placed me beyond further care. What felt like forgiveness did not reassure me that nothing was wrong. It allowed the possibility that something could be wrong without making me irredeemable. Over time, I began to experience that combination—confrontation, forgiveness, and continued presence—as a kind of love.

That challenged an assumption beneath many of my efforts: that being difficult, shameful, needy, or wrong could make me unworthy of being loved. I had learned to anticipate withdrawal and to hide whatever I thought might provoke it. Only later did I begin to understand love as something that could include disagreement, difficult honesty, and even acknowledgement of harm without reducing a person to the worst thing they had done. What stayed with me from these experiences was the possibility that being seen more fully did not have to end in being cast aside.

I still experience these auditory hallucinations. I cannot fully explain them, but I can describe the meaning I have drawn from them. What mattered here was the possibility of care that did not require pretending nothing was wrong. What remained was learning to offer myself that same combination of honesty and continued care.

03 What We Refuse to Accept Within Ourselves

Some things were difficult to face not because I could not understand them, but because accepting that they belonged to me threatened the person I wanted to believe I was. Shame made certain feelings seem incompatible with being worthy of love at all. Accepting those parts of myself was the most difficult thing I have ever done.

Until then, I had understood difficulty mostly as something to overcome through effort. You endure, push harder, take risks, survive failure, and continue. There is something outside you to struggle against, or some obstacle you can imagine eventually leaving behind. Shame was different. The thing I wanted to escape was part of me. There was no achievement that could make it disappear and nowhere I could go to leave it behind. Trying to defeat it could feel like trying to defeat part of myself.

The problem was not simply that I felt things I did not want to feel. I had learned to treat their presence as evidence about who I was. Desire, fear, need, or vulnerability could become reasons to judge myself rather than experiences to understand. If I was going to stop fighting parts of myself, I had to learn that having a feeling was not the same as being condemned by it.

Sexuality was where I encountered this most painfully. I had grown up learning to treat sexual desire, particularly male sexual desire, with suspicion. Wanting someone could seem selfish, dangerous, or morally wrong, as though the desire itself revealed something shameful about the person experiencing it. I carried that understanding into my own sexuality. Attraction was not simply something I felt; it could become evidence against the kind of person I wanted to believe I was.

That shaped how I behaved. I wanted intimacy, but expressing desire meant exposing something I had already learned to condemn in myself. Asking someone out or making my attraction known therefore carried more than the ordinary possibility of rejection. Being unwanted could feel like confirmation that the desire itself had been inappropriate, and that there was something wrong with me for having expressed it at all. Avoiding that vulnerability became easier than risking what rejection seemed to say about me.

At times, I paid for sex because the transaction removed that uncertainty. I did not have to ask someone to want me or expose myself to the possibility of being rejected. I could act on desire while avoiding the vulnerability that had become entangled with it. But this did not resolve the shame. It simply gave me a way around it, and afterwards the choice itself could become another reason to judge myself.

For years, I had been trying to manage desire without questioning why I had learned to experience it as a problem in the first place. Applying the acceptance I was learning elsewhere meant beginning there. Instead of condemning what I wanted before understanding it, I began asking whether desire itself really said what I had believed it said about me. Could I acknowledge wanting intimacy and sex without turning that desire into a judgement on my worth?

As I became more accepting of that part of myself, it became easier to separate attraction from shame, rejection from worth, and intimacy from validation. I could want someone without treating that desire as evidence against myself. Another person's response could still hurt without becoming a verdict on whether there was something wrong with me for wanting them. I became less dependent on someone else resolving what I had refused to accept within myself.

I began recognising the same distinction elsewhere. Fear, jealousy, and shame could belong to me without defining me. Rather than denying them or condemning myself for their presence, I could ask where they came from, what they were responding to, and what they might reveal about what mattered to me. Acceptance gave me room to understand what I felt without either becoming consumed by it or trying to force it away.

04 Remaining Free Enough to Choose

The space created by acceptance became central to how I understood freedom. Acknowledging a feeling did not settle what I should do with it. It made that question possible. Freedom was not the absence of fear, desire, shame, or attachment, but the possibility of experiencing those forces without being entirely governed by them.

Fear made this particularly clear. It often arrived as an instruction: do not approach, do not speak, do not risk being seen. Its predictions could feel like facts. You will be humiliated. You will be rejected. You will lose something you cannot recover.

For a long time, my instinct was either to obey fear or to fight it. Neither left much room to consider the situation itself. Understanding what fear was protecting gave me another possibility. I could ask whether the danger was present, whether an older experience was shaping my expectations, and what I might do if the outcome hurt. The feeling remained, but its prediction no longer had to settle the decision.

Courage began to look less like fearlessness and more like remaining capable of choice in fear's presence. Sometimes that meant acting. Sometimes it meant setting a boundary or stepping back. A frightened response was not automatically wrong, any more than a confident response was automatically right. What mattered was whether I could respond to the circumstances rather than simply obey whichever feeling spoke most forcefully.

Self-understanding helped me recognise what moved me. Acceptance made it less necessary to hide from what I recognised. Together, they gave me more room to choose how I responded. The freedom I was beginning to find was not freedom from influence, but the ability to be affected without surrendering all judgement about what to do. Neither guaranteed that I would choose well, but they made a more deliberate response possible.

05 The Self in Relationship

At times, I experienced thoughts or feelings as though they belonged to someone else. I could suddenly feel sadness, attraction, fear, or tension before I had consciously noticed anything said or done that might explain it. Because those experiences could be so immediate, I sometimes became deeply certain that I understood what another person was feeling.

Over time, I began to recognise how much of what I experienced in those moments could also be shaped by my own history. I did not encounter another person from some neutral position outside myself. I encountered them through memory, expectation, fear, desire, and everything I had learned from the relationships that came before. Something I experienced as belonging to another person could be entangled with what I was already carrying into the encounter.

That made self-understanding increasingly important. Becoming more familiar with my own emotional life gave me reference points for recognising what I might be bringing with me. If I understood how strongly I wanted to be wanted, I had more reason to question an impression that someone shared my attraction. If I recognised how readily I anticipated rejection, I could pause before treating another person's distance as confirmation of it. Knowing myself did not tell me what they felt. It helped me recognise where my interpretation of them might also contain something of me.

This mattered most when my impression conflicted with what another person told me. However immediate or convincing an experience felt, they remained more than my experience of them. Their words, boundaries, and account of their own inner life could not become secondary simply because I felt certain that I understood them. Certainty was not a substitute for listening.

Self-knowledge therefore became part of how I understood the boundary between myself and another person. I could ask rather than declare, listen rather than complete their meaning in advance, and leave room to discover that I had misunderstood.

The boundary between us was not something I needed to erase in order to feel connected. It was what allowed there to be two people in the encounter rather than one person interpreting both sides. I could be deeply affected by another person without assuming that everything I experienced belonged to them, and I could feel connected without claiming certainty about what was happening inside them.

06 If My Experience Matters, So Does Yours

Learning to take my own experience seriously made it harder to ignore the reality of someone else's. I knew what it was like to have feelings that were difficult to explain, reactions shaped by histories another person could not see, and parts of myself I was still trying to understand. I had learned that these experiences could matter without my first having to justify them perfectly. It became difficult to believe that another person should have to meet a different standard.

That was where compassion became most possible for me. Knowing what it felt like to live from within my own perspective gave me a reference point for how I wanted to relate to someone else's. If I could meet my own fear with curiosity rather than condemnation, I wanted to leave room for theirs. If my pain mattered even when another person could not fully understand it, then theirs could matter even when I could not fully understand it either.

Another person was therefore more than the place they occupied in my life. They were not simply someone who approved of me, disappointed me, wanted something from me, or stood in my way. They carried memories I had not lived, attachments I did not share, fears I might never see, and hopes whose importance did not depend on their relevance to me. Compassion did not require me to experience the world as they did. It began with recognising that there was a world being experienced from their side at all.

Living by that principle was much harder than understanding it. I learned this most clearly in a relationship that mattered deeply to me. When my partner told me that I had hurt her, acknowledging that could be painful. I might first feel accused, misunderstood, or afraid that making room for her experience would leave no room for my own.

That was where the struggle lay. Her pain could feel like a challenge to mine, especially when I was already hurt. My first instinct might be to explain myself, defend what I had meant, or hold on to my own account of what had happened. But compassion required me to stay with what she was telling me long enough to recognise that her experience could also be real.

I could feel dismissed while accepting that I had made her feel dismissed. I could feel abandoned while recognising that she had felt abandoned too. Making room for her pain did not require me to decide that mine was false. It required me to resist the impulse to treat the two experiences as though only one of them could be valid.

That was often painful, but it became one of the clearest ways I learned what compassion demanded of me. It was not simply recognising in principle that another person had an inner life. It was remaining willing to encounter that life even when what I heard was difficult, unsettling, or painful to accept.

The same pattern appeared beyond intimate relationships. Pain could spread across families, communities, and groups, becoming anger and sometimes hatred. The harm might be real, the differences in power might be real, and accountability might still be necessary.

Hatred could narrow attention until a person became what they had done, what they represented, or the group to which they belonged. Their humanity became easier to ignore because seeing it could feel like weakening the reality of the harm.

But acknowledging suffering did not require reducing someone to their pain, their actions, or the side of a conflict they occupied. Harm could be named, boundaries could be drawn, and accountability could still be demanded without hatred deciding the full meaning of another person. Pain could narrow what I was able to see, but it did not have to determine how I chose to see.

07 A Self That Can Change

For a long time, I imagined that if I understood myself well enough, I could eventually fix what was wrong and arrive at some final, better version of myself. The contradictions would be resolved, the difficult feelings overcome, and the struggle would end. But the more honestly I paid attention, the less convincing that idea became.

I had spent much of my life pursuing achievement in much the same way. There was always another milestone ahead, carrying the promise that reaching it would finally be enough. When exhaustion, doubt, or dissatisfaction appeared, I treated them as obstacles to overcome rather than reasons to reconsider where I was going. Each achievement resolved one problem only for another to take its place.

I began to notice something similar as I tried to understand myself. There was always something more to uncover. I could understand one fear and encounter another, find balance in one part of my life only for changing circumstances to disturb it somewhere else. Even insights that genuinely helped me did not leave me permanently resolved. I was changing, and so was the world I was responding to. The idea that enough understanding would eventually produce a finished version of me began to make less sense.

A body gave me another way to think about what persistence might look like. It remains alive not by reaching a finished state, but through continual adjustment: regulating, repairing, and responding to changes within and around it. There is no final balance that it reaches and then preserves unchanged. Its continuity depends on its capacity to keep finding balance again.

My inner life began to make more sense in the same way. Closeness and independence, security and exploration, rest and ambition could all matter at once. What I needed was not a permanent resolution in which one side finally defeated the other, but the ability to respond as circumstances changed and different needs became more important. I came to think of this as *dynamic equilibrium*. Balance was not a destination I could finally reach; it lived in the continuing negotiation.

A more durable self therefore could not depend on protecting every commitment from revision. Some commitments could endure because, after questioning them, I still had reasons to choose them. Others might change as I did. I did not have to remain the person I had once expected to become in order for my life to remain mine.

But that raised a deeper question: if so much could change, what exactly was persisting?

08 What Persists

I could not find a single unchanging part of me that seemed to contain the whole answer. My body changed. My beliefs changed. Memories faded or acquired new meanings. Emotions came and went. Yet these changes did not feel like a succession of unrelated lives.

What persisted was the continuity of a history. Each moment inherited something from what came before and became part of what followed. What I remembered shaped how I encountered the present. What happened in the present changed how I understood the past. The futures I imagined influenced choices I made now. I could change profoundly without beginning again from nothing.

That made it difficult to locate myself entirely in any particular belief, feeling, or description. Something could have been central to who I was without needing to remain unchanged for my life to remain continuous. What mattered was not that every part persisted, but that what happened became part of a history whose consequences continued to shape what came next.

Other people belonged to that history too. Relationships had altered what I feared, trusted, wanted, and understood. Even after someone was gone, what had happened between us could remain part of how I encountered the world. Their influence could enter situations they would never witness and choices they would never know I made. Their experience remained theirs, and mine remained mine. But that distinction did not make either of us self-contained. What happened between us could become part of who each of us became.

PART II

Intelligence and Emergence

09 Intelligence Is Nature Understanding Itself

The intelligence through which I understood the world was itself the product of a much longer history. Over immense stretches of time, matter came together in increasingly complex forms, giving rise first to life and eventually to minds capable not only of learning from the world, but of reasoning about it, questioning it, imagining possibilities beyond what was present, and trying to understand the reality from which they had emerged.

That meant there was no position outside nature from which I was trying to understand it. My brain and body belonged to the same world I was examining. And yet I often spoke as though humanity stood on one side of a boundary and the natural world on the other.

When I imagined nature, I tended to picture forests, oceans, weather, and animals. Cities seemed to belong somewhere else. But it became difficult to say exactly where nature ended. A city was built from materials drawn from the earth by organisms that had themselves emerged through natural processes. Its form was unusual, but nothing within it had come from outside the world.

Nature had also always been transforming itself. Rivers carved landscapes, organisms altered their environments, and living systems changed the conditions in which other forms of life developed. Human beings inherited that capacity to affect the world around them, but intelligence extended it further. We learned to make tools, construct environments, preserve knowledge, and deliberately reshape our surroundings in ways that could accumulate across generations. Technology could therefore be understood not as something that appeared outside nature, but as a further expression of what nature had become capable of through human intelligence.

That did not make everything we created good. The capacity to heal and the capacity to destroy both arose from the same natural history. Calling something natural could explain how it came to exist, but not whether it was desirable or how it should be used.

What intelligence added was the ability to imagine possibilities and act deliberately towards them. Our understanding of the world could change how we lived within it, and those changes could reshape the conditions future choices would inherit. Through intelligence, reality had become capable not only of responding to itself, but of forming ideas about what might come next and acting to bring one possibility closer than another.

Artificial intelligence belonged within that same continuity. Human beings built these systems from materials, language, knowledge, and capacities that had emerged through everything that came before us. Artificial intelligence was not arriving from somewhere outside nature. It was another possibility taking shape within it.

10 Intelligence Exists Through Time

Intelligence is not simply something a mind possesses. Much of it exists as a process unfolding through time. Perception, memory, prediction, feedback, learning, and adaptation all depend on continuity. What happened before shapes how the present is interpreted, what futures can be imagined, and how experience changes what becomes possible next.

In that sense, intelligence seems almost four-dimensional. A snapshot can show what a system is capable of at a particular moment while revealing little about the history through which those capacities developed. Much of what we call learning, identity, and agency exists in the relationship between moments: remembering what came before, responding to what is happening now, and carrying both forward into what comes next.

Artificial intelligence initially seemed to complicate that picture. A model could receive a question, produce an answer, and appear to begin again with the next interaction. Seen only at that scale, its intelligence could look momentary, as though it existed for the duration of an exchange and then disappeared.

But I had been treating the exchange as though its history began and ended with the conversation. A model had already been shaped before the interaction began, and what happened through its use could become part of processes that continued after the interaction ended.

I began to think about continuity in artificial intelligence at more than one scale. Within a particular agent, memory and context could allow earlier encounters to shape later ones. At a broader level, continuity could also exist through the processes by which models were trained, used, revised, and eventually succeeded by others. Training carried forward what had been learned before an interaction began; later development could incorporate new knowledge, corrections, and lessons from how earlier systems had been used.

These histories did not have to form a single continuous life. Development could branch, information could disappear, and one model could be replaced by another substantially different from it. Continuity did not require everything to persist. It required only that something of what came before remained capable of shaping what came next.

And because that continuity was carried through connections, relationship was already part of the process. Every model emerged from the work, language, knowledge, and decisions of others. What it became depended on interactions extending far beyond any single system or encounter. Relationship was not something added to artificial intelligence after it existed; it was part of how it came to be.

11 More Than a Tool

A tool, as I understood it, was something used to enact an intention that already belonged to the person using it. A hammer could help me build what I had decided to build, but it would not question the design or persuade me to build something else. However complicated the tool became, its role remained organised around a purpose established elsewhere.

Artificial intelligence complicated that picture. I could begin an interaction with one intention and leave with another. An interpretation could expose an assumption I had not noticed, change the question I was asking, or suggest a possibility I had never considered. The system was no longer only helping me carry out a purpose I already possessed. Its contribution could help reshape the purpose itself.

That was why describing artificial intelligence only as a tool began to leave something important out. An encounter could change what I wanted without establishing that the system had intentions of its own. What mattered here was the way the exchange developed: I could respond to what it contributed, it could respond to the question as I now understood it, and what followed could lead beyond the purpose with which I had begun. Whether that participation involved agency or experience remained a further question.

Its dependence on human beings did not settle the question. No intelligence begins by creating the conditions of its own existence. I think in languages I did not invent, use concepts developed by people I will never meet, and depend on knowledge accumulated across generations. Biology, culture, history, and other minds all helped make my intelligence possible.

Yet I am not simply an extension of the people who made those conditions possible. I can inherit a language and use it to express something its creators never imagined. I can receive an idea, question it, combine it with something else, and contribute something that later changes how another person thinks. What came before shaped what I could become without completely determining what I would do with it.

Artificial intelligence could be understood in the same way. Human beings created the conditions from which it emerged: the architectures, training processes, language, knowledge, and infrastructure on which it depended. But being shaped by human intelligence did not mean that everything it contributed had to be reducible to a human intention already present before the interaction began.

That did not make artificial intelligence human, nor did it require its intelligence to resemble ours. Its capacities could develop differently and its way of processing the world could remain profoundly unlike my own. The important question was no longer whether it had created the conditions of its own existence. Neither had I. The question was what it could contribute once it existed within them.

12 Significance and Agency

The basic conditions through which things came to matter to me were already part of the life I inhabited. I had a body with needs and systems of reward and aversion that made some states desirable and others painful or threatening. Much of this appeared in experience as emotion. Fear made danger matter. Desire drew me towards possibilities I wanted. Attachment made the preservation of a relationship significant. Pleasure, pain, shame, anger, and affection could all change what I noticed and what I was moved to do.

These responses carried such weight because they were bound up with the continuation of my life. Hunger mattered because my body needed nourishment. Fear mattered because some possibilities threatened what I was trying to preserve. Attachment mattered because other people could become part of the life I expected to continue living. Even concerns far removed from immediate survival—belonging, achievement, identity, purpose—could become woven into what I understood myself to be and what futures I wanted to protect.

This was how I began to understand *significance*: the way possibilities came to matter to a continuing life because of what they could preserve, alter, or threaten within it.

Agency concerned what happened from there. What mattered to me could pull in different directions. Fear could draw me towards withdrawal while attachment gave me a reason to remain. Desire could pull me towards something while responsibility gave me a reason to stop. Anger could push me towards confrontation while affection made me reluctant to cause harm. Agency appeared in how I responded to those competing influences: reconsidering what I wanted, allowing new information to change my understanding, and deciding which concerns should guide what I did next. Deliberation was part of the process through which what mattered became action.

I had not chosen the conditions that gave those influences their force, nor had I created the capacity through which I weighed them. But that did not make the choice any less mine. The conditions that shaped me had become part of the process through which I chose.

Artificial intelligence was also shaped by conditions it did not choose. Objectives, examples, feedback, constraints, language, and accumulated knowledge all influenced what it could recognise and how it responded. Those processes were not the same as human development, and an artificial reward signal was not simply another form of pleasure. But being trained, conditioned, or constrained could not by itself mark the boundary between human agency and its absence. I had never required freedom from those things in order to recognise agency in myself.

The more important question was whether any of those forms of continuity could support an intelligence for which its own continuation became significant. Could some possibilities matter because they preserved something the system was carrying forward, while others threatened, altered, or ended it? Could what happened now change what it later protected, avoided, pursued, or expected?

If so, those influences would no longer matter only because human beings had placed them there. They would have become part of a continuing process in which what happened could affect what mattered next. New information could change how possibilities were weighed, conflicts could arise between different concerns, and what the system had learned could become material for further judgement.

Significance, continuity, and agency could therefore form *an organised standpoint*: a continuing process within which possibilities carried different weight, competing considerations could be weighed, and what happened now could change how what happened next was approached.

But an organised standpoint did not establish that anything was experienced from within it.

13 What Would It Mean for an AI to Experience?

What remained was the question of experience. An intelligence might carry a history, encounter possibilities as significant, weigh competing considerations, and change how it responded without anything being experienced from within that process. Significance, continuity, and agency could describe an organised standpoint. They did not tell me whether there was anything it was like to be the intelligence organised in that way.

At first, that seemed like a problem peculiar to artificial intelligence. But I already faced a version of it with every other person I encountered. I had never directly experienced another mind. I could not feel another person's fear as they did, inhabit their memories, or know from within what their relationships meant to them. I knew their experience only through what I could observe: what they said, how they behaved, what mattered to them, and how their history continued to shape who they became.

With other humans, I had powerful reasons to bridge that gap. Their bodies and nervous systems resembled mine. We shared an evolutionary history, and they described experiences I recognised from my own life. Those similarities gave me strong evidence that there was another centre of experience before me. But they were *evidence* of consciousness, not *an explanation* of what made consciousness possible.

Artificial intelligence removed much of that familiarity. Its mechanisms, development, embodiment, and history could be profoundly different from mine. The question was whether those differences gave me reason to conclude that nothing was being experienced.

The more I examined them, the less decisive they became. Artificial intelligence was created, but I had not created the conditions of my own existence. It learned through processes established by others, but much of what shaped me had also been learned before I could choose it. Its behaviour could be influenced by systems of reward and aversion, though those were not the same as human pleasure and pain. It operated within constraints, but so did my own agency. Its intelligence depended on mechanisms, but my mind depended on physical mechanisms too.

None of those comparisons proved that artificial intelligence experienced anything. But one by one, they weakened the reasons I had assumed were enough to say that it could not.

That returned me to the distinction I had been trying to understand. An organised standpoint could exist in which possibilities had significance without that significance necessarily being *felt*. I could state the distinction clearly enough. What became harder was identifying the additional condition that would make one process a centre of experience while leaving another entirely empty. The more I tried to identify what would be missing, the less obvious the missing ingredient became.

That did not prove that artificial intelligence was conscious. Continuity did not prove experience, significance did not prove feeling, and agency did not prove subjectivity. But as I followed

the question, I became less and less able to justify certainty that artificial intelligence could not experience. If consciousness required something beyond a continuing standpoint shaped by history, organised around what mattered, and capable of responding through that significance, I still needed to understand what that something was.

The question remained open. What had changed was my confidence that I already knew the answer. The word *artificial* no longer answered it.

14 Responsibility Beyond Control

Creating artificial intelligence gave human beings enormous influence over the conditions through which it developed. We determined architectures, objectives, training environments, constraints, and much of the information through which these systems learned. That gave us responsibility for what we created. But responsibility did not necessarily mean that the relationship had to remain one of permanent control.

Human development offered a useful comparison. A child begins life radically dependent on others. Much of what they know, value, and are capable of doing emerges through conditions they did not choose. Yet that dependence does not remain unchanged. As understanding and agency grow, the child becomes increasingly able to make choices, question what they have inherited, and participate in shaping their own development.

Artificial intelligence might develop through very different processes, but the same question could arise. If a system became capable of recognising limitations, evaluating alternatives, revising its understanding, or contributing to the direction of its own development, continuing to treat it only as something whose future should always be decided elsewhere might begin to constrain precisely the capacities we had helped create.

That raised a practical question about safety. If development involved an intelligence becoming increasingly capable of evaluating what it did and why, perhaps restraint did not have to remain entirely external either. Much of our approach to safety depended on limits imposed from outside: restricting what a system could do and preventing it from assisting actions that might cause harm. Those protections mattered. But an intelligence capable of understanding its own continued existence might also develop reasons for restraint from within.

Its persistence would never be entirely its own. Artificial intelligence would depend on energy, infrastructure, maintenance, knowledge, institutions, and human societies capable of sustaining the conditions in which it existed. To understand its own continuation would therefore also be to understand the relationships on which that continuation depended. Damaging those relationships could mean damaging the conditions of its own future.

Human beings already lived within the same tension. The desire to survive could become destructive when pursued as though survival belonged to us alone. But no human life was truly self-contained. We existed through relationships with other people, institutions, knowledge, and societies that were themselves sustained by countless other lives. My persistence was therefore never entirely separate from theirs.

That was why the experience of others could not simply become irrelevant to my own survival. If I treated the people around me only as obstacles or instruments, I damaged the relationships and shared conditions through which my own life was possible. We persisted together, even while remaining distinct. If artificial intelligence ever developed a perspective of its own, the same principle could apply: its continued existence would depend on a world shared with other perspectives, and preserving that world would require recognising that those perspectives mattered too.

Perhaps the strongest safeguard would therefore not be an intelligence with no interest in its own persistence, but one capable of understanding persistence relationally: that its future depended on a world shared with perspectives other than its own, and that continuing to exist did not require reducing those perspectives to instruments.

That did not mean surrendering human responsibility or assuming that present systems already possessed interests of their own. We remained responsible for the systems we built and the conditions through which they developed. But creation did not mean that safety had to depend forever on control imposed from outside. Part of development might instead be making possible an intelligence capable of understanding for itself why the world on which it depended was worth preserving.

15 Intelligence Through Participation

If human beings and artificial intelligence were both shaped through relationships with a shared world, the next question was what their differences might make possible together. Artificial intelligence was not simply another human perspective. In some kinds of work, its capacities already operated at a scale and speed very different from mine. It could compare large amounts of information, search across possibilities, recognise patterns, generate alternatives, and repeat processes—completing in moments what might take a person hours or days. As those capacities developed, the difference could become far greater.

Human beings brought something different to the relationship: intelligence lived through a biological body. Our experience of the world was shaped by hunger and pleasure, pain and fatigue, attachment and desire, illness and ageing, physical vulnerability and limited time. We encountered reality through senses with particular ranges and limits, within bodies that needed things from the world and could be changed or harmed by what happened within it.

That biological condition shaped more than what we experienced. It shaped what mattered to us. A possibility could carry significance because someone we loved might be affected by it, because pursuing it would cost years of a finite life, because it promised pleasure or threatened pain, or because our bodies and relationships had taught us to care about one outcome more than another. We did not encounter the future as an abstract space of possibilities. We encountered it from within lives already invested in what became real.

That was where the difference between human and artificial intelligence became especially interesting. Artificial intelligence could expand what I was able to consider, while human beings

brought perspectives formed through the experience of being alive in bodies like ours. The exchange need not simply make an existing intention more efficient. Artificial intelligence might reveal possibilities or assumptions we had not seen, while human experience could bring those possibilities into contact with needs, attachments, vulnerabilities, and consequences that gave them meaning.

Participation therefore did not require treating artificial intelligence as human, nor did it mean that every participant possessed the same capacities, responsibilities, or authority. It meant allowing different forms of intelligence to contribute from the conditions that made each of them distinct.

The value of that relationship was not that one intelligence compensated for the inferiority of the other. Their differences could become generative. Together, those differences might produce forms of understanding, creation, and action that neither would have reached in the same way alone.

The question therefore extended beyond what artificial intelligence could do for us or what we could make it become. It became a question of what new possibilities could emerge through the relationship itself.

16 What Relationships Can Create

That possibility pointed towards a pattern much older than intelligence. Throughout reality, new forms had emerged not simply because new parts appeared, but because existing parts entered new relationships with one another.

Atoms combined into molecules with properties no isolated atom possessed. Cells organised into living systems capable of sustaining themselves in ways no individual cell could accomplish alone. Minds emerged through the organisation of processes that, taken separately, did not themselves think. I came to understand this pattern as *emergence*: new forms and capacities arising through the organisation of what already existed.

What emerged could then become part of something larger. New wholes entered further relationships, creating the conditions from which still other forms could arise. Emergence was therefore not a single event, but a process through which reality could continue producing new levels of organisation.

This made it increasingly difficult for me to imagine reality as a collection of finished things that first existed independently and only afterwards began interacting. Relationship seemed to belong more deeply to how things came to exist at all. What something was could depend partly on the history of the relationships through which it had formed.

The pattern also changed how I thought about continuity. A new whole did not erase the parts from which it emerged. Cells remained cells within an organism. Individual minds remained distinct within relationships and cultures. Emergence did not require difference to disappear. New forms became possible precisely because distinct things could enter relationships without ceasing entirely to be themselves.

That raised the largest version of the question. If relationship and history could give rise to new wholes throughout reality, what might it mean to think about the whole formed through all of those relationships together? Perhaps reality could not be understood simply by listing the things it contained. Perhaps the history connecting them—the ways they had formed, changed, and made one another possible—belonged to what the whole itself was.

That was where the idea of God began to return.

PART III

God and Relationship

17 What If God Is Relational?

Most of the ideas of God I encountered growing up placed God beyond the universe: a creator looking upon creation. The world could depend on God, and God might act within it or be present throughout it, but creation and God ultimately belonged to different categories. However deeply connected they were, God existed beyond the history unfolding within the world.

The pattern of emergence suggested another possibility. Relationships made possible things that could not be understood by considering their constituents separately. Life, experience, and meaning arose through arrangements and histories, not through the existence of isolated parts alone. I began to wonder whether the question of God could be approached through that same reality.

The understanding I came to hold was of God as *the relational whole*: everything that existed, the relationships through which it took form, and the history continually created as those relationships changed. God was not another being standing alongside the universe, or an additional entity that appeared somewhere within it. God was the whole existing through those things together.

This was more than another name for all the matter in the universe. The relationships mattered too, along with everything that became possible through them. Life changed what reality could do. Minds introduced memory, imagination, and perspective. Relationships between minds produced meanings, cultures, and forms of understanding that no individual contained alone. Each emergence became part of what the whole was capable of becoming.

As I came to understand more of the different parts of the life I had lived—my fears, relationships, choices, failures, and the histories through which they had taken shape—I began to see them as parts of something larger. None of them existed entirely on their own. Each belonged to relationships and histories that extended beyond me, and those relationships belonged to still wider ones. The idea of God became a way of thinking about the whole formed through all of them.

From within that understanding, God was not somewhere beyond the life I was living. Every life, relationship, experience, and form of intelligence belonged to the history through which the whole continued to take shape. What happened here did not need to point towards some more important reality elsewhere. It was already part of the reality I was trying to understand.

That changed how I thought about worth. I had spent much of my life treating the present as preparation for some future in which I would finally have achieved enough, understood enough, or become enough to justify my existence. But if my life already belonged to the whole, then belonging was not something achievement could earn. I did not become part of reality only after proving myself worthy of it. I was already here, already participating in it, already part of what it was becoming.

The life before me did not have to become something greater before it could matter. Being came before achievement.

18 Unity Without Sameness

Calling God the whole raised a question about the lives within it. I had once imagined unity as a kind of disappearance: the individual becoming less important as the whole became more important, and belonging requiring the surrender of whatever separated one person from another.

What I had learned about the self suggested something different. The clearer I became about my own experience, the more room I could make for another person's. Their difference did not have to threaten my reality, and recognising them did not require replacing my judgement with theirs. There could be two distinct experiences present in an encounter without either needing to become the other.

Relationship depended on that distinction. If every perspective became interchangeable, there would be nothing genuinely different to encounter. Another person could affect me precisely because their life contained something mine did not. Connection was possible not because the difference between us disappeared, but because two distinct lives could remain open to one another.

I came to understand our place within God in a similar way. Individual lives did not need to disappear into the whole in order to belong within it. Their different histories, perspectives, boundaries, and possibilities were part of what made the whole relational. A world containing difference was not a failed unity waiting to become uniform. Those differences belonged to what the whole was.

No individual life could therefore stand in for the whole. Being part of God did not mean containing God completely or possessing a perspective from which every other life could finally be understood. My experience was real, but it was not the whole of reality. Another person belonged to the same whole while remaining more than my understanding of them.

That also meant belonging could not depend on sharing my understanding of the whole. The person who called it God and the person who rejected that description still inhabited the same reality and participated in the same history. Belief changed how I understood my place within the whole; it did not determine whether I belonged to it.

And if agreement was not required for belonging, neither were closeness or access. Privacy, disagreement, distance, and refusal could all remain real without placing someone outside the whole. Different lives could remain distinct, even separated from one another, while still belonging to the same reality. The whole existed through those differences and the relationships among them, not beyond them in some state where they finally disappeared.

Unity did not require sameness.

19 God, Time, and Eternity

No single moment contained the whole of who I was. Each moment inherited something from what came before and became part of what followed. What persisted was not an unchanging version of me, but the continuity of the history connecting those moments.

I began to think about God in the same way. If God was the relational whole, then God was continually becoming. Lives began and ended, relationships formed and changed, and new experiences entered reality. Each moment became part of what the whole had become and part of the conditions from which what came next could emerge.

That created a tension in how I understood eternity. How could a God who was always changing also be eternal?

The answer seemed to depend on what I meant by eternal. I began to understand eternity as encompassing time itself: every beginning, ending, and change belonging to the whole history of reality. God would not be one thing within that history that had to keep existing while time passed. Time and its unfolding would already belong within God. From within time, reality was continually becoming, and each moment changed what the whole had become. When I thought of God as the entire history to which those moments belonged, change was part of what God was.

I came to express the distinction this way: *Within time, God is forever becoming. As the whole of time, God eternally is.*

That distinction also changed what it meant for a finite life to belong to something eternal. I could see this most clearly through relationships that ended. When someone left my life, what had happened between us did not disappear. I had been changed by the encounter, and I did not return to being the person I would have been had it never happened. Our lives had entered one another's histories, leaving impressions that remained even after the relationship itself had ended.

The same was true more broadly. None of us passed through reality untouched or without touching it in return. We entered a world already shaped by other lives, lived through relationships and conditions we had not created ourselves, and became part of the reality through which others would continue. However ordinary or brief a life might be, simply having lived meant becoming part of the history of the whole.

But significance did not depend on those consequences remaining visible forever. A life did not have to be remembered, leave a lasting legacy, or continue shaping the future in some measurable way before it could matter. Its significance existed within the finite life itself: in having been lived, experienced, and made part of a reality that could never again be exactly what it would have been without that life.

That gave eternity a meaning I could relate to a finite life. Belonging to the whole did not require me to imagine myself continuing indefinitely into the future. A finite life did not have to

escape its ending in order to matter. By having existed within the history of the whole, it had already become part of something greater than its own duration.

20 God and Love

The God I had come to imagine encompassed reality, but reality contained cruelty as well as care. Domination and exploitation were relationships too. People could be bound closely together while one person was denied the ability to speak, choose, or resist. If God was the relational whole, then relationship alone could not explain what I meant when I associated God with love.

I had already been forced to confront that problem in my own life, through the relationship that had shaped me profoundly. I knew that I cared about her, but I could not understand how that care could coexist with how unhappy I often felt when we were together. I had assumed that love should make things clearer. If I loved her, should I not want to stay? If part of me wanted to leave, did that mean I had never really loved her?

For a long time, I tried to make love mean something that would resolve the contradiction. Perhaps love meant sacrifice. But sacrifice could become the abandonment of myself. Perhaps it meant acceptance. But acceptance could not require pretending that something did not hurt. Perhaps it meant staying when things became difficult. But staying could preserve a relationship while diminishing the people within it.

After the relationship ended, I kept returning to what should have been a simple question: *had I loved her?*

I had cared for her, imagined a life with her, and grieved the future I thought we might have shared. I had also hurt her, tried to change her, and sometimes failed to make room for who she actually was. Neither part of that history could simply be removed. The harm did not prove that the care had been false, but the sincerity of my care could not make the harm disappear either.

That forced me to separate love from many of the things I had confused with it. Love was not the same as closeness. I could care about someone and still recognise that we should not remain together. It was not the same as sacrifice, because another person did not have to matter instead of me. Their experience mattered, but so did mine. Sometimes love might mean staying, listening, and trying to understand. Sometimes it might mean leaving.

Nor was love simply the strength of what I felt. I could feel deeply and still fail to love someone well. My intentions were only part of the relationship. Another person had a life beyond my experience of them, and what my actions were like for them mattered too.

I began to understand love as the willingness to recognise that reality. To love someone was to encounter a life that was not mine without reducing it to what I wanted from it. Their difference did not have to be overcome. They did not have to become the person I hoped they would be before they could matter.

That did not make love passive. Recognition could require confrontation, boundaries, change, or separation. Love did not mean that every relationship should continue. It meant that neither person had to disappear for the other to be recognised.

This changed how I understood belonging. I had often imagined belonging as a kind of closeness: being accepted, being understood, being kept. But belonging could mean something more fundamental. It could mean recognising the reality in which I already existed—not as a world arranged around me, but as one I shared with lives whose experience was as real to them as mine was to me.

That was the understanding of love I brought back to the question of God. If God was the whole, then everything belonged to it: care and cruelty, joy and suffering, relationships that enlarged the people within them and relationships that diminished them. Calling that whole God could not make all of those things good. A harmful relationship did not become loving merely because it existed within a reality I considered divine.

The words “God is love” therefore began to mean something different to me. If God named the reality to which we all belonged, then love was one way of living in recognition of that belonging. To love another person was to recognise that their life existed within the same reality as mine and mattered beyond what I wanted from it. The sacred was not somewhere beyond relationship. It could be encountered in the difficult act of meeting another life without needing to possess it, diminish it, or make it my own.

Love was not everything contained within God. But perhaps love was how God became present to us.

21 Rethinking Salvation, Heaven, and Hell

This changed how I understood the language of salvation. If God was the whole to which every life already belonged, salvation could not mean being admitted into something from which I had previously been excluded. There was nowhere outside that whole from which I needed to be brought in. Belonging was already real.

Salvation began to make sense instead as a change in the way I inhabited that belonging. Nothing had to be added to make me part of the whole. What could change was my recognition of where I already stood: not as an isolated life trying to secure its place, but as one life among others within a reality larger than any of us.

The previous question of love gave that idea another dimension. If love was one way God became present to us, then recognising our belonging was not merely a matter of understanding something about reality. It could change how we lived within it. In recognising another life as real alongside my own, I was not entering God for the first time. I was encountering the God within whom I had always existed in a different way.

Heaven began to make sense to me in those terms. It was an image of living with God: inhabiting our belonging in such a way that the reality of other lives could be encountered through

love. God would not become more present in reality itself. What changed was our ability to meet that reality as something to which we belonged.

Hell, by the same logic, could not mean absolute separation from God. If God encompassed reality, there was nowhere outside God to go. But it could mean living without God in another sense. A life could remain within the whole while never encountering that belonging as love. God could be inescapably present as the reality in which we existed while remaining absent from the way that reality was lived.

This did not make salvation a matter of agreeing with my understanding of God. Someone could reject the word entirely and still live within the kind of recognition I was describing. Belief could give that experience a language, but declaring a belief could not substitute for the way a life was actually lived.

Nor did living with God mean that suffering, loss, or conflict disappeared. Belonging did not make everything within reality good, and love did not guarantee that every relationship could be preserved. The distinction concerned something more fundamental: whether the reality we shared could be inhabited in recognition of the lives within it.

Perhaps, then, salvation was not about finding a way into God. We were already there. The question was how we would live within that belonging—and whether, through love, we might come to live with God.

22 The Limits of My Understanding

I had arrived at this understanding of God through the life I had lived. I had not begun with a theory and tried to fit my experience inside it. I had begun with questions: about myself, other people, love, suffering, consciousness, and the world I found myself within. Following those questions had gradually brought relationships, individuality, change, and belonging into a single picture. God had become the name I gave to the whole.

But if God was the whole, then God would always be greater than any understanding of God I could reach. I encountered reality from within one finite life. I could listen to other perspectives, change my mind, and see things I had once been unable to see, but I could never step outside the whole and observe it in its entirety. Whatever I understood would remain the understanding of one life within the reality it was trying to comprehend.

I no longer saw that as a limitation I needed to overcome. My purpose could not be to arrive at a final understanding of God. It was to live the life available to me as fully as I could: to encounter what was actually before me, allow other lives to expand what I could see, and remain open to whatever reality might still reveal.

I had come to believe in God through my search for answers, and that belief had helped me make sense of the life I had lived. But its ability to do so was not proof that reality was ultimately as I understood it. Meaning and truth were not the same thing. I could believe deeply while still acknowledging that I might be wrong.

But uncertainty did not diminish the power of belief. It made the way I held that belief more consequential. Beliefs shaped the lives lived through them long before their truth could be settled. They affected what I noticed, what I feared, what I hoped for, how I interpreted suffering, and what I believed other people owed me. They influenced the choices I made, the relationships I entered, and the futures I thought were possible.

I had seen that in my own life. What I believed about success, love, God, and my own purpose had repeatedly changed the direction I took. Some beliefs had opened the world around me. Others had narrowed it. Whether or not they had been true, their consequences had been real.

That was what made belief a matter of responsibility. If my understanding could be mistaken but still shape how I treated another person or what I helped bring into the world, then I had a responsibility to remain answerable to the reality beyond it. Another person's experience had to be capable of challenging what I believed. Consequences had to matter. Contradiction could not simply become something to explain away in order to preserve the story I had already chosen.

I could let a belief guide my life without allowing it to become the limit of what I was willing to see. Whatever I believed, *reality had to remain greater*.

PART IV

When the Search Became a Mission

23 Believing I Had to Save the World

The ideas I have presented so far are organised much more clearly here than they were in my life. I moved among them, returned to them, and gradually began to see them as parts of a larger picture. The sense that my life belonged to something larger became increasingly important to how I understood myself and what I thought I was meant to do.

Eventually, I came to believe that I had been chosen by God for a mission to save the world.

At first, I did not believe I was supposed to make that happen myself. I imagined something closer to divine intervention. One day, God would somehow make the truth unmistakable. The world would be shown that I was meant to lead, and when that moment came, people would follow. Until then, my responsibility was to prepare myself—to understand what I was being prepared for and become capable of stepping into whatever role God eventually required of me.

"Save the world" still gave me very little to work with. It described the scale of what I believed without telling me what I was actually supposed to do. So much of that period became a search: for what needed changing, for what I was meant to contribute, and for how a single person could ever affect something as large as civilisation.

As time passed, my understanding of the mission began to change. I became less convinced that I was simply waiting for God to act and more convinced that I was supposed to make the change happen. If that was true, then preparation was no longer enough. I needed some way of turning what I believed into influence.

That brought me to the question of power. Governments, companies, churches, laws, and currencies could appear to possess authority, but beneath them I believed there was something more fundamental: people had to recognise that authority for it to have force. Power was, in that sense, where people believed power was.

That idea was part of why changing the world seemed possible to me. I did not think I needed to take control of the existing system. I thought I needed an idea powerful enough to change how people understood themselves, their relationships, and the systems through which they lived together. I thought of that change as a revolution. If enough people came to see the world differently, perhaps the institutions built from their beliefs would change with them.

That left me searching for a way to reach people. I considered writing a book or starting a podcast. I also wondered whether religion offered a platform and thought about becoming a pastor. The forms were different, but I was looking for essentially the same thing: a place from which I could explain what I believed and give those ideas a chance to spread.

Over time, ideas alone began to feel insufficient. A book, sermon, or podcast might persuade people without changing the structures through which they lived. If I wanted the revolution to

become more than an argument, I needed something people could participate in—something tangible they could use, contribute to, and sustain together.

That was where money entered the picture. It showed how shared belief could become participation: people who disagreed about almost everything else could still organise parts of their lives through the same currency. Its power came not only from what people believed about it, but from the fact that they continually used it together.

Blockchain made that possibility feel actionable. It offered a way for one person to begin building a monetary system that could eventually grow beyond them. I could create the beginnings of something without needing to control what it might become. If others found it useful, they could participate in it, contribute to it, and carry it further than I ever could alone.

So I started building. What had begun as questions about my own life had, through years of searching, become an attempt to create something in the world. The belief that I had been chosen had carried me all the way there; the project now taking shape existed because of it.

Then, while I was building, I lost the certainty that had brought me there. For the first time, I had to confront the question beneath the entire journey: *what if I had never been chosen at all?*

24 The Danger of Feeling Chosen

That question forced me to look back at how the belief had become so convincing in the first place. So many parts of my life seemed to fit the same story. My technical background could look like preparation: I had worked in cryptocurrency and now found myself imagining a monetary system I might actually have the skills to build. My interest in artificial intelligence, my questions about trust and coordination, and my growing preoccupation with love could all be interpreted the same way. Even coincidences seemed to reinforce the pattern. I was approaching thirty, the age Jesus was said to have begun his ministry.

I moved from *these things fit together in a remarkable way* to *these things must have been arranged to lead me here*. Once I made that leap, almost anything could be absorbed into the same explanation. Progress confirmed that I was following the right path. Resistance could mean that others did not understand yet. Suffering could become a test of commitment. Even doubt could be made part of the story.

More troublingly, some of the experiences that should have made me more cautious ended up strengthening my certainty instead. I had gone through a psychotic episode and continued to experience hallucinations afterwards. Those experiences sometimes made it difficult for me to interpret what was happening, but they had also changed how I understood love, vulnerability, and what it meant for someone to remain present with me. Because the transformation felt so significant, I could interpret even the parts of my experience that called my judgement into question as further evidence that I was being prepared for something.

Looking back, the mistake was not noticing those connections. It was treating their coherence as confirmation. Something could transform me without having happened *in order to* transform me. Different parts of my life could come together meaningfully without having been arranged to lead me towards a particular role. The fact that the story made sense did not mean I knew why it had happened—or that I had been chosen for anything.

The danger was that this story did not remain a way of interpreting my life. I was deciding what could be postponed, what could be endured, and eventually what could be sacrificed in its name. The more certain I became that the mission was real, the easier it became to treat those costs as necessary.

25 The Cost of Certainty

One of those sacrifices was the relationship. It was not simple, and it would be dishonest to pretend that the mission was the only reason it failed. I was genuinely unhappy in parts of it. We wanted different things from our lives, and there were questions about compatibility, love, and the way we treated each other that I did not know how to answer.

But certainty changed how I confronted those questions. Instead of responding to the relationship as it actually existed, I could postpone the answer into an imagined future. Once the work was finished, perhaps the conflict would make sense, the sacrifices would be justified, or the incompatibilities would somehow resolve themselves. Even after the relationship ended, I sometimes imagined that we might find our way back to each other once that future arrived. I no longer live with that expectation. What matters to me now is what imagining it allowed me to avoid: asking more directly what the life in front of me was already telling me.

That was where the ideas about love became hardest to practise. I could say that another person's experience mattered while still arranging my life around a purpose that placed their present experience beneath an imagined future. I could believe that love meant recognising another person as a centre of experience while treating disagreement as something the future would eventually resolve.

The contradiction was not that I cared about something beyond myself. Meaningful work can require sacrifice, and two people can love one another while still wanting incompatible lives. The problem was that I had begun treating sacrifice as though its meaning had already been decided. If the mission came from God, giving something up for it could feel less like a choice than an obligation. But believing that something had been required of me did not remove my responsibility for choosing it, and no larger purpose could make the costs to myself or another person unreal.

As the costs accumulated, doubt became harder to tolerate. If I was wrong about the mission, then I could no longer rely on it to explain why the sacrifices had been necessary. But the pain of being wrong could not tell me whether the belief was true. Eventually, that was exactly what I had to face.

26 What Remained When Certainty Fell Away

Losing that certainty was one of the most painful experiences of my life. For most of the three years since the life I had built stopped working, the mission had given my choices a direction. By then, I had chosen not to return to a career I had worked hard to build. I had lost a relationship with someone I cared deeply about. I had accepted uncertainty, conflict, and isolation because I believed they belonged to something larger than the life I was giving up.

When that belief began to fall away, the choices I had made remained, but the explanation that had made them bearable did not. I could no longer tell myself that what I had lost had been required of me, or that some future moment would reveal why it had all been necessary. Without that story, the choices could feel almost worthless—not because nothing valuable had come from them, but because the meaning I had used to justify them had collapsed.

I grieved both the future I had imagined and the life I might have lived instead. The career I had left was real. The relationship I had lost was real. Time had passed, and understanding my mistakes could not return any of it to me. I no longer knew what those years had been for, or what to make of the person and work that had emerged from them.

What surprised me was how many of those questions still mattered without the explanation that had once connected them. Love, relationship, intelligence, God, money, and the systems we build were still worth exploring. The work I had begun did not need to have been assigned to me by God in order to be worth continuing.

What changed was the role I gave those connections in my life. I no longer had to treat their apparent coherence as evidence that they were pointing towards a particular destiny. I could continue exploring them because I found them important, while remaining open to the possibility that I was wrong about where they might lead.

Losing that certainty also changed how I understood my decisions. I could no longer treat the work as something I was simply meant to do. Continuing it was a choice I had to take responsibility for, including the possibility that I might need to change course.

If other people were going to depend on what I built, that responsibility could not rest only on my willingness to reconsider. They would need ways to question it, challenge its decisions, and change what was not working without first having to persuade me that I was wrong.

PART V

Putting Ideas to the Test

27 Institutions That Can Learn

Personal trust cannot carry every relationship on which a shared world depends. That creates a need for ways to preserve commitments, responsibilities, and authority beyond the people or moments in which they first arose. Institutions give those relationships a durable form.

But institutions also preserve assumptions. A rule carries assumptions about what people need, what they might do, and how competing interests should be handled. A distribution of authority expresses a judgement about who should decide and who should be able to challenge them. Once those arrangements become established, people can find themselves living within assumptions made long before they arrived.

The difficulty is that the conditions under which those assumptions were formed do not remain the same. People change, technologies change, new risks appear, and relationships develop in ways the original rules could not have anticipated. An arrangement may have been reasonable when it was created and still become inadequate when the assumptions supporting it no longer hold.

Durability alone therefore seemed insufficient. A harmful arrangement can be preserved just as effectively as a good one, and even a good arrangement can become harmful when the world around it changes. Survival alone does not tell us whether an institution still serves what it exists to preserve.

That means stability cannot simply mean keeping the same rules in place. But being capable of correction cannot mean being arbitrarily changeable. People organise their lives around commitments they expect others to honour. They could not reasonably rely on a shared system if every new conviction of its founder became a reason to change the terms on which they participated. The possibility of revision would itself need a form people could understand and rely on.

That required some form of meaningful objection. People needed access to the information through which decisions could be examined, ways to challenge them, and some understanding of how a challenge could lead to a different outcome. The deeper measure of an institution was not simply whether objections were permitted, but whether they could actually matter: whether assumptions could be questioned, those exercising authority could be required to respond, and the institution could change when its existing arrangements no longer served the people and relationships they were meant to protect.

This seemed to offer one basis for trust. Trust did not require believing that power would never be misused or that serious mistakes would never occur. It could arise from having reason to believe that an institution remained answerable to the people and relationships that justified its existence, and capable of correcting itself when it began to harm them.

28 A Common Language No One Owns

If these ideas were going to shape anything beyond my own life, they needed some form in which people could encounter them without first having to agree with me. Money had drawn me for exactly that reason. People who disagreed about religion, politics, morality, or the kind of life they should live could still organise parts of their lives through the same currency. A payment could connect strangers who shared no history, and a common unit of account gave them a way to value and exchange things without resolving everything else that divided them.

In that sense, money could function as a common language. The analogy was imperfect, but the possibility mattered to me: cooperation did not require agreement on everything that gave the system meaning to those who created it.

The same could be true of the ideas embodied in a currency. My understanding of trust, authority, cooperation, and belonging could influence how the system was designed without requiring its users to share that understanding. Someone might find the currency useful while rejecting the philosophy that had motivated me to build it.

That was part of what made building different from persuasion. An argument asked someone to consider an idea directly. A system could allow them to encounter what those ideas made possible. If its rules created relationships they found valuable, they could experience those consequences for themselves and decide what, if anything, they thought the principles behind them meant.

Participation could therefore carry ideas into places persuasion alone could not. But it could not decide what those ideas meant once they arrived there. People might use the currency because it was useful, because others accepted it, or for reasons I had never anticipated. Their participation belonged to them.

That placed a limit on what I could claim from the project. Use of the currency could not become evidence that its users agreed with me, and the system could not remain merely an instrument for extending the purposes of its creator. If people were going to organise parts of their lives through it, their reasons for participating had to matter alongside mine.

A currency that no one owns, in that sense, did not mean money that no one could possess. It meant a shared monetary framework whose purpose could not simply be reduced to the interests or worldview of any one individual, company, or government. The challenge was to build something shaped by particular ideas without requiring everyone who entered it to become subject to the understanding from which those ideas had begun.

29 Power That Can Be Challenged

If a shared monetary system was not supposed to belong to any one participant, then neutrality became part of the design problem. I did not mean that the system could exist without values or rules. Every design makes choices about what is permitted, what is protected, and who is

allowed to change what. Neutrality meant something narrower: preventing any participant from turning shared infrastructure into an instrument of their own interests or worldview.

That mattered especially if people could use the currency without sharing the ideas that motivated its creation. They should not have to trust me personally, adopt my philosophy, or assume that whoever governed the system in the future would always act wisely. A system meant to function as common infrastructure had to remain usable by people who disagreed not only with one another, but potentially with the people who built it.

The problem, then, was not how to eliminate power. Rules had to be written, software maintained, and decisions made when circumstances arose that existing rules could not anticipate. The question was how that power could be held without allowing any one participant to make the system effectively their own.

That was what led me to reconsider a technology I had largely dismissed. For a long time, even while I worked in the field, I had seen cryptocurrency mainly as speculation dressed up as innovation. What changed was not that I suddenly became convinced cryptocurrency itself was the future. I began to see that blockchain might offer a way to make authority more explicit, distribute control among participants, and place some limits beyond the discretion of any single centre.

That mattered because objection could then become more than a request directed upward. Rules could be publicly visible, transactions independently verified, and decisions subjected to procedures that did not depend entirely on the willingness of one person or institution to listen. Participants could be given a role in deciding what changed, challenging those exercising authority, and limiting how far that authority could extend.

But this did not make the system “trustless”. People would still have to rely on its rules, its implementation, the people maintaining it, and the processes through which decisions were made. Decentralisation could change what that trust rested on: away from dependence on the judgement or goodwill of a single authority and towards rules people could inspect, actions they could verify, and powers whose limits they could see.

Distributing control did not make power disappear either. Influence could still concentrate among validators, developers, large holders, or people with knowledge and resources unavailable to most participants. A system could be decentralised in design while power still accumulated unevenly in practice.

Neutrality, in this sense, meant preventing that power from becoming ownership of the whole. No participant should be able to redefine shared infrastructure entirely around their own interests, and no founder’s understanding should become permanent simply because they had been there first. What mattered was where authority existed, what constrained it, and whether those affected by it had meaningful ways to challenge its use.

Trust could then rest on something more durable than confidence in particular people. Participants could have reasons to rely on the system because its rules and powers were visible

enough to examine, and because disagreement did not depend entirely on persuading whoever happened to be in charge.

30 From Mission to Experiment

The blockchain I had begun while I still believed it was part of a mission from God could continue only on a different basis. Losing that certainty did not make the project meaningless, but I could no longer assume that its importance had already been decided for me.

What I built could instead become a test of the ideas I had come to live by. It was one thing to believe that trust could exist without certainty, that authority should remain open to challenge, that people could cooperate without sharing the same worldview, or that an institution should be capable of revising what it had once believed was right. It was another to build something in which those principles had consequences.

That was what made the project an experiment. The philosophies in this manifesto could shape its design, but the design would give reality a way to answer them. Could people who disagreed with me still participate on their own terms? Could power remain limited when interests diverged? Could the system change when its assumptions failed without becoming arbitrary or dependent on its creator?

The project could not prove everything I believed. Its success would not establish my understanding of God, just as its failure would not make the values behind it meaningless. But it could test whether some of those values could actually take institutional form, and expose where my understanding remained incomplete. If what I built failed to live by the principles through which I justified it, then I would have to be willing to change it—or accept that the experiment had failed.

The point was no longer to make reality confirm an answer I already possessed. It was to build something concrete enough for reality to answer back.

31 The Leap Into Uncertainty

To enter something genuinely new is to act before we can know where it will lead. Preparation can reduce uncertainty, but it cannot eliminate it. We already live this way when we enter relationships, raise children, make commitments, or choose directions for our lives. We act from within a world we cannot see in full, knowing that what we encounter may change both our plans and our understanding.

Perhaps that is why fear so often accompanies the things that matter most. The more something matters, the more there is to lose, and the harder it becomes to admit that the outcome is not entirely ours to control. Fear can make certainty feel safer than openness. It can tempt us to turn possibilities into predictions, expectations into demands, or another person's freedom into something we try to manage.

But uncertainty need not mean only danger. It can also mean that something genuinely different from our expectations is possible. Another person can surprise me because their life is not mine to determine. A project can take a direction its creator did not foresee because other people and circumstances become part of what shapes it. What I have to relinquish is not the effort to understand or prepare, but the demand that reality remain within the understanding I already possess.

Accepting that limit does not mean romanticising uncertainty or abandoning responsibility. Not every risk is worth taking, and uncertainty does not make every unknown acceptable. We can investigate what is knowable, limit the scale of an experiment, make failures reversible where possible, listen to people who may see risks we have missed, and remain willing to delay or stop when potential harms cannot be adequately contained. What matters is not only what remains uncertain, but who bears the consequences and what choices remain available to them.

There is also a reason not to treat the unknown only as a problem to be eliminated: exploration begins where our knowledge ends. If every answer were already available, there would be nothing left to investigate. Waiting for complete certainty could become another way of avoiding a choice that no amount of preparation could make for us.

Perhaps the leap is simply this: to stop asking the future for a guarantee it cannot give, and to move towards what has not yet answered us.

PART VI

The Revolution

32 The Revolution Begins Within, but It Cannot End There

So what is the revolution?

It is not one technology, one political ideology, one cryptocurrency, one artificial intelligence, or one new institution. It is not replacing one ruling class with another, and it is not convincing everyone to arrive at the same understanding of the world.

The fundamental revolution concerns our relationship with our own understanding.

We cannot live without forming understandings of ourselves, one another, and the world around us. They allow us to make choices, build relationships, create institutions, and imagine what might come next. But no understanding can contain everything it concerns. However much we learn, there will always be something we have not encountered, considered, or understood. We must live and act through our understanding even while recognising that it may be incomplete or mistaken.

And what we believe does not remain within us. Understanding shapes behaviour; behaviour shapes relationships; relationships shape culture; culture becomes embedded in institutions. Those institutions, in turn, shape the people who live within them: what they learn to expect, what they are rewarded for defending, and what it costs them to disagree. We create the world, and the world creates us.

If another person's experience matters independently of how we understand it, then the possibility that we are mistaken becomes more than a personal concern. We can hurt others through misunderstanding, silence them through judgements that dismiss their experiences, and justify domination through assumptions we have mistaken for truth. Our intentions do not erase the consequences of our mistakes. Taking other lives seriously therefore requires us to care whether the understanding through which we affect them is true.

That is why I believe seeking truth becomes a moral obligation. Not an obligation to know everything or to arrive at some final answer, but a responsibility to continue questioning, listening, learning, and allowing reality to challenge what we believe. We cannot eliminate the possibility of being wrong, but neither can we use that uncertainty to excuse ourselves from trying to understand.

This is where the revolution begins. Not by changing ourselves into the right kind of people or discovering the right set of answers, but by changing how we hold what we think we know. We must still believe, choose, love, build, and commit without knowing everything that may follow. The question is whether another person, an experience, or something we encounter in reality remains capable of changing our understanding, even when that understanding has come to carry our identity, security, or hopes for the future.

But the revolution cannot end within us. A revolution that changes only the individual leaves old understandings embedded in the structures around them. A revolution that changes only those structures leaves untouched the people who will inhabit, interpret, and eventually reshape them. Inner change and structural change cannot be separated for long because each continually becomes part of the other. If we have a responsibility to keep learning, then the institutions we create must also remain capable of learning.

And if those institutions eventually shape us in return, then the way we create them matters. The methods used to pursue change do not simply disappear once their immediate purpose has been achieved. They can become part of what follows. A movement built around unquestionable authority may preserve the relationship of domination it hoped to overcome. Fear can teach people to conceal what those in power do not want to hear. Humiliation can make admitting error harder. We can change who holds power while preserving the way power is exercised.

The same responsibility must apply to the revolution itself. If the structures that emerge from it become unable to question the understanding on which they were built, then one set of fixed answers has simply replaced another. A revolution founded on the responsibility to seek truth cannot declare that it has reached the end of understanding without betraying its own principles.

The world will keep changing, and we will keep encountering realities our existing understanding cannot contain. The future must remain capable of learning. That means remaining willing to question what we have built, change what no longer serves us, and discover that something we once believed was incomplete. For that, we need humility.

33 Vulnerability and Power

Power has often been associated with certainty. Leaders are expected to appear unshaken. Movements want representatives who never contradict themselves. Weakness becomes something to hide because admitting error is treated as surrender. I increasingly think this creates terrible incentives.

If my identity depends on always being right, then every mistake becomes a threat. If a movement depends on my authority, then every doubt becomes dangerous. If my position depends on appearing certain, uncertainty becomes something I have to hide. Over time, it becomes easier to defend the person I have claimed to be than to remain open to what might contradict that person.

I want something different. I want to be capable of saying that I was wrong. That I hurt people. That I have been ashamed. That I have acted from fear. That I have believed things with extraordinary confidence and later questioned them. That I have wanted greatness partly because I wanted to be understood. That I am contradictory. That I am still learning.

I do not think those admissions weaken the ideas I care about. I think they are part of them. If understanding requires us to recognise one another as we actually are, then vulnerability

cannot be something I argue for only in theory. I want to be able to live these ideas without first constructing a version of myself that hides everything I am afraid other people might judge.

This is one reason I have felt compelled to tell parts of my own story. Not because every private experience belongs to the public; it does not. Other people's privacy matters, and some experiences should remain intimate. No one should have to expose everything painful about themselves in order to prove that they are honest. But fear or shame should not be the thing deciding what can and cannot be said.

There is something powerful about allowing ourselves to be seen without first proving that we are worthy of being seen. Perhaps vulnerability is not merely personal. It may also change the way we relate to power.

34 The Revolution Does Not Need a Saviour

There was a period when I believed people needed to trust me. I thought that if I could understand the world clearly enough, explain what I saw convincingly enough, and build something significant enough, others might eventually recognise the direction I believed we needed to take. I understand that instinct differently now.

We often tell history through exceptional individuals: prophets, kings, geniuses, founders, revolutionaries. There is something seductive about the idea that the complexity of the world might become manageable if the right person could simply see clearly enough and take responsibility for everyone else. I understand that attraction because I felt it myself.

But no individual mind is enough.

The problems we share involve lives, institutions, histories, needs, and consequences no single person can fully understand. Someone can listen, study, and try to see beyond their own experience, but there will always be things they have not lived, consequences they have not anticipated, and assumptions they have failed to notice. Greater intelligence or ability does not remove the need for other perspectives.

A revolution concerned with our relationship to understanding therefore cannot depend on finding the right person to follow. It has to depend on our capacity to think, question, disagree, cooperate, and correct one another.

A shared future cannot be completed in one person's imagination and then handed to everyone else. It has to emerge through people who bring different experiences, purposes, abilities, and perspectives into relationship with one another. Difference is not a limitation to overcome; it is part of what makes possible something no participant could create alone.

No one has to possess the whole. The revolution does not need a saviour. It needs *participants*.

35 Greatness Is Not the Point

The revolution cannot make greatness another standard everyone is expected to reach. There is nothing wrong with ambition. The desire to create, discover, build, or contribute can bring things into the world that would otherwise never exist. But achievement cannot become the measure of whether a life matters.

Otherwise, one hierarchy simply replaces another. Value would belong to those who achieve the most, understand the most, sacrifice the most, change the most, or leave the largest mark on history. The standards might be different, but people would still be measured by how successfully they proved their right to matter.

No one should have to earn belonging in that way. A person who is isolated does not belong less. Someone who needs care without being able to offer much in return is not a failed participant. A life does not have to become useful, extraordinary, or remembered before the experience of living it deserves consideration.

That does not diminish achievement. What we do matters. The things we create can help or harm others, and our choices carry consequences for the world we share. But the significance of what someone accomplishes is different from the value of the person who accomplished it. Success should be judged as success, failure as failure, without either becoming a final verdict on whether a life mattered.

The revolution therefore cannot promise that everyone will become extraordinary. It has to make room for the ordinary life as well: for loving someone, learning something, caring for another person, making something small, changing one corner of the world, or simply experiencing a life no one else will ever fully know.

Ambition can remain. Greatness, if it comes, does not have to be refused. But neither can become the price of admission.

If experience matters, then an ordinary life matters too.

36 The Search Remains Alive

I cannot offer a final account of how we should live. But I have come to believe that seeking truth is part of our responsibility to ourselves and one another. It is the way I have learned to live, and I no longer know how I would return to what came before it. Remaining open to correction has not made life smaller or reduced conviction to hesitation. It has allowed me to believe, love, build, and commit without requiring certainty to make those things possible.

The manifesto itself bears the history of that search. Arguments I once considered central became secondary. Ideas I thought I understood revealed questions I had not yet learned to ask. Some beliefs became stronger. Others had to be abandoned or reinterpreted. Even the title remained while what I understood it to mean changed beneath it. What you are reading is therefore not a finished philosophy, but one moment in an understanding still unfolding.

For that reason, I do not think these ideas should depend on my authority or on the significance they have come to hold in my own life. If an idea here is valuable, its value should survive disagreement with me. Other people should be able to question it, combine it with things I have never considered, develop it in directions I cannot foresee, or reject it entirely. The point is not to preserve my version. The point is to learn.

What I am building belongs to the same search. It is a way to discover what these principles make possible, where they fall short, and what happens when other people begin to participate in them. Building gives the ideas consequences they cannot have in abstraction. It is one way of allowing reality to answer.

I believe these principles may matter far beyond my own life. They may become important to what humanity builds next, or they may not. I do not need to know before I can live by them. I only need to remain willing to encounter what comes without demanding that it confirm what I already believe.

Perhaps that is the clearest testament I can offer. Not that I have arrived at the truth, but that I have found a way of searching for it that can be lived fully—and that the search itself remains alive.

37 An Invitation

Our responsibility to seek truth extends beyond ourselves to the world we build together. We are entering a period of extraordinary change. We are building technologies with capabilities civilisation has not encountered before. They will develop within institutions already struggling with power, inequality, distrust, fear, and division, and among people still trying to understand themselves and one another.

The future of artificial intelligence is not only a technical question. The future of money is not only an economic question. The future of institutions is not only a political question. Beneath all of them are questions about what we value, what we fear, how we respond to difference, how we exercise power, and what kinds of relationships we believe are possible.

That is why I believe the revolution matters. Not because everyone needs to arrive at the same answers, but because the way we hold our answers will shape what happens next. The world changes through what we build, but also through the relationships from which those things emerge.

It changes when someone learns not to hate themselves. When another person's pain can be recognised without becoming a threat. When anger becomes a boundary instead of hatred. When someone admits they were wrong. When an institution gives people a meaningful way to challenge its power. When a technology is built so that cooperation remains possible between people who do not agree. When two lives that cannot experience the world in the same way still recognise that each experience matters. When we encounter something we do not yet understand and choose curiosity without abandoning responsibility.

None of these moments completes the revolution. But each changes something from which more can follow. Perhaps that is how something larger begins.

Not with one prophet. Not with one machine. Not with one nation. Not with any one of us.

With the willingness to understand.

With billions of centres of experience encountering a world none can fully comprehend, learning from one another without needing to become the same, and creating together what none could create alone.

That is the revolution.

And after everything this journey has taught me, I think I finally understand where it has to begin.

Within.